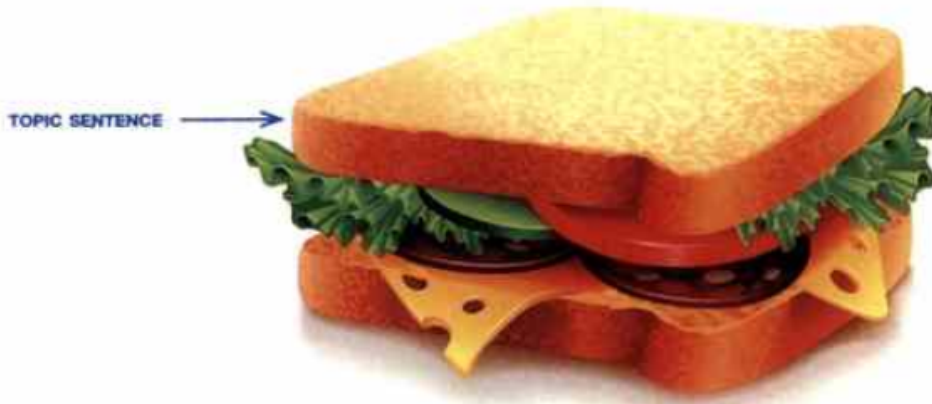


## THE TOPIC SENTENCE

The most important sentence in a paragraph is the **topic sentence**. It is called the topic sentence because it tells readers what the main idea of the paragraph is. In other words, it tells readers what they are going to read about. The topic sentence is usually the first sentence in a paragraph. It is the top piece of bread in our paragraph "sandwich."



A topic sentence has two parts: 1) a **topic**, which tells what the paragraph will be about, and 2) a **controlling idea**, which tells what the paragraph will say about the topic. It tells the reader: This paragraph will discuss these things—and only these things—about this topic.



In the topic sentence, the topic can come before or after the controlling idea:

BEFORE: English borrows words from other languages.

AFTER: Other languages give words to English.

BEFORE: English is necessary for many different jobs.

AFTER: Many different jobs require English.

**PRACTICE 3****Analyzing Topic Sentences**

Look at each group of topic sentences. Circle the topic and underline the controlling idea of each sentence. (You will use these groups of sentences again later.)

**GROUP 1**

1. Good roommates have four characteristics.

1. Topic Sentence: To be an effective CEO requires certain characteristics.
2. Topic Sentence: There are many possible contributing factors to global warming.
3. Topic Sentence: Fortune hunters encounter many difficulties when exploring a shipwreck.
4. Topic Sentence: Having a first child is difficult because of the significant adjustments in your life.
5. Topic Sentence: It is important to be ready before buying a house.
6. Topic Sentence: There are many reasons why pollution in ABC Town is the worst in the world.

**PRACTICE 4****Recognizing Topic Sentences**

Find the topic sentence in each paragraph. Circle the topic and underline the controlling idea.

**PARAGRAPH 1****Libraries**

Libraries offer people a wide variety of activities. Reading, of course, is one of the main activities. People browse the shelves to find interesting books to borrow, and they also come to read newspapers and magazines. Using computers is another popular activity. People can read articles online or do research. They can also check their email, shop, or contact their friends on social networking sites. Studying is also a popular activity. Many students come to the library after school to do their homework or study for tests. Some libraries even have areas where students can study together and talk quietly. Indeed, libraries are for much more than simply reading books.

**PARAGRAPH 2****Libraries**

Libraries are busy from morning until night in my city. In the morning, you can find retired people and others who aren't working. Some come to borrow books, read newspapers and magazines, and use the computers. Others bring their preschool children in order to read to them or to take part in story hours. In the afternoon, students come to the library. They use the computers, do their homework, or work together on assignments. In the evening, the library is also quite busy. People come to relax after work, and families often visit after dinner. In short, people use libraries all day long for a variety of reasons.



### **PARAGRAPH 3**

#### **Libraries**

A good place to volunteer in your community is a library. First, libraries use volunteers to sort and put books back on the shelves. You can learn how to do this with only a few hours of training. Second, some libraries use volunteers to help people use the computers. You can help people learn how to find information and send emails. In addition, libraries often use volunteers to help out in the children's area. You can lead story hours or help children with special art and reading projects. Finally, libraries use volunteers as tutors. For example, you can volunteer to help students with their homework or become a conversation partner for someone learning English. To sum up, libraries welcome many different kinds of volunteers.

### **PARAGRAPH 4**

#### **Libraries**

Over the past 20 years, many changes have taken place in libraries. First of all, libraries now have computers for people to use. Usually, there is no charge to use the computer for research or for surfing online. Second, there are fewer records, cassette tapes, and video tapes. These have been replaced by CDs and DVDs. In addition, many libraries now have a kiosk where you can check out your books using a computer. Finally, libraries have become more social and community-oriented than they were in the past. They are now places where people come to discuss ideas, learn a craft, study with friends, or join a community group. As our world changes and technology improves, libraries continue to change to meet the needs of the people who use them.



**PRACTICE 5****Choosing Topic Sentences**

- A** Read the paragraphs. Circle the letter of the best topic sentence for each one and write it on the line.

**PARAGRAPH 1**

\_\_\_\_\_ Living in a foreign country has a number of benefits.

\_\_\_\_\_ First, living in a foreign country helps you learn another language faster than studying it at school. Second, you can learn directly about the history, geography, and culture of a country. Third, you become especially knowledgeable about different cultures and different ways of living. Fourth, living in a foreign country makes you appreciate your own country more.

- a. Living in a foreign country helps you learn.
- b. Everyone should live in a foreign country for a while.
- ☒ c. Living in a foreign country has a number of benefits.

**PARAGRAPH 2**

\_\_\_\_\_ \_\_\_\_\_ Some colleges and universities in the United States are private. Private colleges and universities do not get money from taxes, so they are usually more expensive. Other colleges and universities are public; that is, the citizens of each state pay some of the costs through their taxes. As a result, public colleges are cheaper for students to attend. No matter which type of college you attend—public or private—you can get a good education.

- a. There are two main types of colleges and universities in the United States.
- b. Public colleges and universities get money from taxes.
- c. There are many colleges and universities in the United States.

**PARAGRAPH 3**

\_\_\_\_\_ One reason for choosing a small college is that classes are small. The average class in a small college is 20 students. Another reason is that it is fairly easy to meet with professors. Professors in small colleges have time to help students and are usually happy to do so. In addition, small colleges are friendly, so new students make friends quickly. For these three reasons, small colleges are better than large universities for many students.

- a. Small colleges are friendlier than large universities.
- b. There are several reasons for attending a small college instead of a large university.
- c. You can get an excellent education at a small college.

**PARAGRAPH 4**

\_\_\_\_\_ First of all, employers want workers to be dependable. That is, they want workers who come to work every day. Second, employers want workers who are quite responsible. Can the boss give the worker a project to do and know that it will be done well? Third, employers look for workers who can work well with others. The ability to get along with coworkers is extremely important to the success of a business. To summarize, employers look for dependable, responsible team players.

- a. It is difficult to find good employees these days.
- b. Employers read job applications very carefully.
- c. Employers look for three main qualities in their employees.

- B** Read the paragraphs. Then write a topic sentence for each one.

**PARAGRAPH 1**

Colleges and universities in the United States offer several different types of degrees. An associate's degree is given for a two-year program of study. Most students at a community college earn an associate's degree. Students at a four-year college or university earn an undergraduate degree, also called a bachelor of arts (BA) or bachelor of science (BS). Some students continue their studies by doing postgraduate work at a university. After several years, they can receive a graduate degree, such as a master's degree (MA) or a doctorate (Ph.D., doctor in philosophy). In short, there are several types of college degrees in the United States.

**PARAGRAPH 2**

\_\_\_\_\_ First, good teachers know their subject extremely well. That is, a math teacher has advanced education in mathematics, and an English teacher knows a lot about English grammar. Second, good teachers are especially good communicators. This means they know how to present information in ways that students can understand. Third, good teachers are enthusiastic. That is, they can show students that they are interested in their subject and that the subject is quite fun to learn about. To summarize, good teachers have expert knowledge, good communication skills, and enthusiasm for their subject.



### PARAGRAPH 3

\_\_\_\_\_ The first type of shopper doesn't like to waste time. She knows what she wants to buy and how much she wants to pay. If the store has what she wants, she buys it and leaves. She is a good kind of customer because she doesn't take too much of a salesperson's time. A second type of shopper comes into a store with a general idea of what she wants, listens to the salesperson's suggestions, looks at a few items, and makes a decision. She is also a good kind of customer. A third kind of shopper has no idea what she wants. She spends two hours trying to decide which item to buy. She takes up a lot of a salesperson's time and sometimes doesn't buy anything. In conclusion, the first two types of shoppers are a salesperson's dream, but the third type is a salesperson's nightmare.

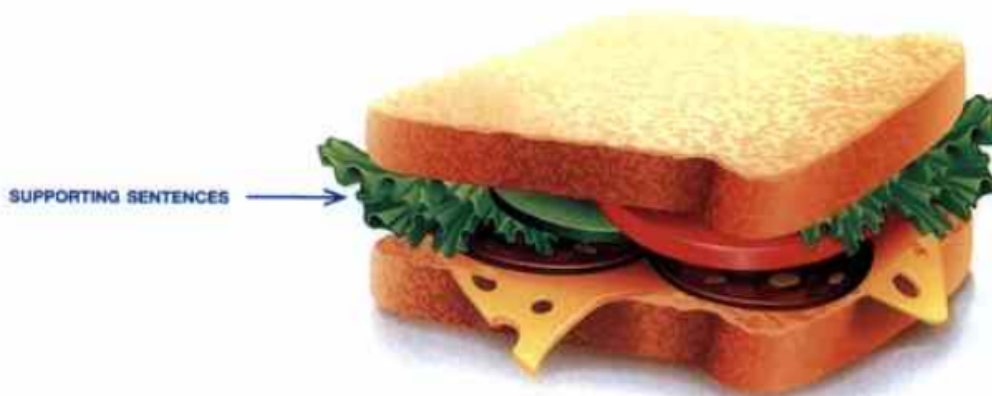
### PARAGRAPH 4

1. \_\_\_\_\_  
 \_\_\_\_\_  
 First, you need to have enough time to request and then submit all the necessary academic records. Often it takes a long time for records, such as transcripts or standardized test scores, to arrive at the university. You must be sure that this paperwork reaches the university before the application deadline. Second, the admissions office must have enough time to look at your academic records and decide whether you will be accepted. Finally, many universities have a quota, or special number, of students who may enter every semester. If you apply too late, there may not be room for you for the semester in which you want to enter. Following these simple steps can help you get into a university quickly and easily.



## SUPPORTING SENTENCES

Supporting sentences follow the topic sentence in a paragraph. Supporting sentences explain or prove the ideas in the topic sentence. They are the “filling” in a paragraph “sandwich.” The supporting sentences are the biggest part of a paragraph, just as the filling is the biggest part of a sandwich.



Supporting sentences are divided into *main points* and *supporting details*

### DETAILED PARAGRAPH OUTLINE

|                                                              |
|--------------------------------------------------------------|
| Topic Sentence                                               |
| A. Main Point (reason, benefit, and so on)                   |
| 1. Supporting Detail (example, fact, description, and so on) |
| 2. Supporting Detail                                         |
| 3. Supporting Detail                                         |
| B. Main Point                                                |
| 1. Supporting Detail                                         |
| 2. Supporting Detail                                         |
| 3. Supporting Detail                                         |
| C. Main Point                                                |
| 1. Supporting Detail                                         |
| 2. Supporting Detail                                         |
| 3. Supporting Detail                                         |
| Concluding Sentence                                          |

While the **main points** are *mandatory*, the **supporting details** can be *optional*. That means if the **main points** are *clear and detailed enough*, there is *no need for further supporting details*

Task: Read the following paragraph and fill in the chart that follows

**PARAGRAPH 2**

A good teacher should have the following qualities.

\_\_\_\_\_ First, good teachers know their subject extremely well. That is, a math teacher has advanced education in mathematics, and an English teacher knows a lot about English grammar. Second, good teachers are especially good communicators. This means they know how to present information in ways that students can understand. Third, good teachers are enthusiastic. That is, they can show students that they are interested in their subject and that the subject is quite fun to learn about. To summarize, good teachers have expert knowledge, good communication skills, and enthusiasm for their subject.

Topic Sentence: \_\_\_\_\_

A. Main Point: \_\_\_\_\_

1. Supporting Detail: \_\_\_\_\_

B. Main Point: \_\_\_\_\_

1. Supporting Detail: \_\_\_\_\_

C. Main Point: \_\_\_\_\_

1. Supporting Detail: \_\_\_\_\_

Concluding Sentence: \_\_\_\_\_

Work alone or with a partner. Add supporting points for the topic sentences in Group 1 from Practice 3 on page 41. Write your points in the spaces provided. You may write phrases or sentences.

1. Good roommates have four characteristics.

- a. are neat, tidy
- b. are cheerful
- c. share housework
- d. pay their share of the rent on time

2. College students face many challenges.

- a. \_\_\_\_\_
- b. \_\_\_\_\_
- c. \_\_\_\_\_

3. Living with your parents has certain advantages.

- a. \_\_\_\_\_
- b. \_\_\_\_\_
- c. \_\_\_\_\_

4. Successful student athletes have several characteristics.

- a. \_\_\_\_\_
- b. \_\_\_\_\_
- c. \_\_\_\_\_

5. Small colleges are better than big universities for several reasons.

- a. \_\_\_\_\_
- b. \_\_\_\_\_
- c. \_\_\_\_\_





Unity is an important characteristic of a well-written paragraph. When a paragraph has unity, all the sentences in it are about one main idea. Another way of saying this is that all the supporting sentences must be **relevant**, which means “directly related to the main idea.” For example, if your paragraph is about your mother’s good cooking, a sentence such as *My sister is also a good cook* is **irrelevant** (that is, not relevant) because the paragraph is about your mother, not your sister. When you write a paragraph, make sure that all of your supporting sentences are relevant.

#### **PRACTICE 8**    Editing for Unity

Work alone or with a partner. Each paragraph contains two irrelevant sentences. Circle the topic and underline the controlling idea in each topic sentence. Then draw a line through each irrelevant sentence.

##### **PARAGRAPH 1**

##### **Boston**

Boston is one of the most popular U.S. cities with college students.

There are two main reasons for this. First, students enjoy being in a city that is full of other college students. The Boston area has over 50 colleges and universities, including Boston University, Massachusetts Institute of Technology, and Harvard University. ~~The Charles River, between Boston and Cambridge, is famous for boating and races.~~ Because of the large number of college students, there are many events and activities in the city every day. Second, Boston has the feel of a big city, but it’s really rather small. It is quite convenient for students to get around using public transportation. It is very easy for students to become familiar with the city and feel comfortable. There are many friendly neighborhoods near the colleges, and students usually feel welcomed. However, some Boston residents complain about noisy or irresponsible college students. It’s no surprise that people regard Boston as one of the top U.S. college towns.

## **PARAGRAPH 2**

### **Nurses**

Good nurses should have at least five characteristics. First, they must be caring. They must show genuine concern for sick, injured, or frightened people. Second, nurses must be extremely organized. If a nurse forgets to give a patient his or her medicine on time, the consequences could be serious. Third, nurses must be quite calm. They may have to make a life-and-death decision in an emergency, and it's clear that calm people make better decisions than anxious people. Doctors also need to stay calm in emergencies. In addition, nurses should be physically strong because nursing requires a lot of hard physical work. Finally, they must be intelligent enough to learn difficult subjects such as chemistry and psychology and to operate the complex equipment used in hospitals today. There is a shortage of nurses today, so they earn good salaries. In brief, nursing is a profession for people who are caring, organized, calm, strong, and intelligent.

## **PARAGRAPH 3**

Advances in medicine can come from surprising places, including water. Many scientists are interested in the medical uses of small aquatic<sup>3</sup> animals. They believe these animals are useful for new medical products. Some ancient civilizations used berries and grasses for medical purposes. These plant-based medicines were often quite effective. In the future, important drugs may be made from aquatic organisms. In addition, these organisms may be used as models to understand human diseases. Many years from now, sea creatures may help people lead healthier and longer lives.

## LISTING-ORDER TRANSITION SIGNALS

ELLT.ir

To show readers that they are moving from one supporting idea to another, good writers use words or phrases known as **transition signals**. A transition signal alerts the reader that the writer is moving on to the next supporting idea. It also shows how the new supporting idea is related to the previous idea.

In a listing-order paragraph, you can use transition signals such as *First*, *Second*, and *Third* to show the reader the order of the main points.

Here are some transition signals that show listing order:

| LISTING-ORDER TRANSITION SIGNALS |              |
|----------------------------------|--------------|
| First,                           | ... also ... |
| First of all,                    | ..., also.   |
| Second,                          |              |
| Third,                           |              |
| In addition,                     |              |
| Also,                            |              |
| Finally,                         |              |

Most listing-order transition signals come at the beginning of the sentence, followed by a comma.

**First**, living in a foreign country helps you learn another language faster than studying it at school.

**In addition**, small colleges are friendlier, so new students make friends more quickly.

**Also**, studying is a popular library activity.

The transition signal *also* is an exception. You can use it at the beginning of a sentence with a comma (as in the example above), but you can also use it with a verb (without a comma) or at the end of a sentence (preceded by a comma).

Studying is **also** a popular library activity.

Students **also** like to study in the library.

Studying is a popular library activity, **also**.

**Note:** When you want to give examples as supporting details, use the following signals:

|                             |                   |                                                                                                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| for example<br>for instance | To add an example | Most colleges now have a writing requirement for graduation. <b>For example</b> , students at my college must pass a writing test before they register for their final semester. |
|-----------------------------|-------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|



- B** Complete the paragraph with listing-order transition signals. Add commas where needed. For some, there may be more than one answer.

### Kinds of Intelligence<sup>1</sup>

There are many kinds of intelligence. First,  
1. there is mathematical-logical intelligence. People with this kind of intelligence become mathematicians, scientists, and engineers. \_\_\_\_\_  
2. there is linguistic<sup>2</sup> intelligence. People with linguistic intelligence are good at language, so many become musicians and writers. We are familiar with these first two kinds of intelligence, but other kinds are not so familiar. There are \_\_\_\_\_  
3. spatial intelligence and musical intelligence. Spatial intelligence is necessary for architects and artists, and musical intelligence is necessary for musicians. \_\_\_\_\_  
4. there is kinesthetic<sup>3</sup> intelligence. Athletes and performers have kinesthetic intelligence. Personal intelligence is a kind of intelligence \_\_\_\_\_  
5. People with personal intelligence manage people well, so they become leaders of society. In short, there is more than one way to be smart.

<sup>1</sup> This paragraph is based on the work of Howard Gardner, a professor at the Harvard Graduate School of Education.

<sup>2</sup> **linguistic**: related to language

<sup>3</sup> **kinesthetic**: related to movement of the human body





## ACTIVITY 2 | Writing supporting sentences

Read the paragraph. Then study the supporting sentences for the first and third ways to avoid a cold. Write a supporting sentence or two for the second way.

### WORDS TO KNOW Paragraphs 5.3

**Increase:** (v) to go up in number, amount

**spread:** (v) move from one person to another

#### PARAGRAPH 5.3

### How to Avoid Being Sick with a Cold

There are three ways to avoid becoming sick with a cold. The first way is to wash your hands several times during the day. Washing with soap helps kill germs<sup>1</sup> that can **spread** a cold from someone else to you. The second way is to eat foods that have lots of vitamin C. \_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

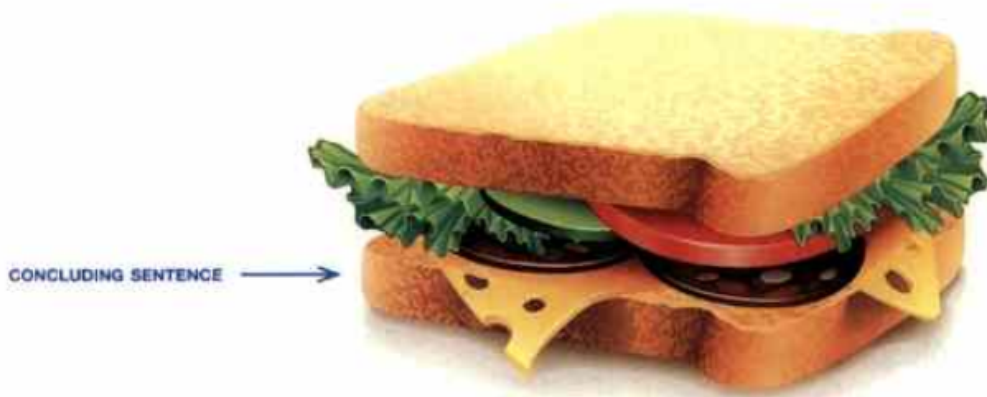
\_\_\_\_\_

Finally, a very important step to avoid getting sick is to be well rested. This means you should sleep for at least six hours every night. Being tired makes your body weaker, and this **increases** the chance of getting sick. I suggest following these simple recommendations to avoid getting a cold.

<sup>1</sup>germs: small living things that can cause illnesses or disease

## THE CONCLUDING SENTENCE

Paragraphs that stand alone (that is, paragraphs that are not part of a longer composition) often end with a **concluding sentence**. A concluding sentence signals the close of the paragraph to the reader.



Here are several points to keep in mind about concluding sentences:

- Sometimes a concluding sentence reminds the reader of the main point by restating the topic sentence in different words.

In short, there are several types of college degrees in the United States.

It's no surprise that people regard Boston as one of the top U.S. college towns.

- Sometimes a concluding sentence summarizes the main points.

To summarize, employers look for dependable, responsible team players.

In brief, nursing is a profession for people who are caring, organized, calm, strong, and intelligent.

- Writers often use a **conclusion signal** to show their readers that this is the end of the paragraph. The chart lists several conclusion signals. Notice that there is always a comma after a conclusion signal.

| CONCLUSION SIGNALS             |                                            |                                   |
|--------------------------------|--------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------|
| To conclude,<br>In conclusion, | To sum up,<br>To summarize,<br>In summary, | In brief,<br>In short,<br>Indeed, |

**PRACTICE 9****Choosing Concluding Sentences**

Read the paragraphs. Circle the letter of the best concluding sentence for each one, and write it on the line.

**PARAGRAPH 1**

There are two reasons I love big cities. First of all, big cities are alive 24 hours a day. You can go shopping, see a movie, exercise at a gym, get something to eat, or go roller skating at any time of the day or night. Second, in big cities you are free to do whatever you like. No one watches your daily comings and goings. You can stay out all night or stay home all day, and no one will judge you. \_\_\_\_\_

- a. To sum up, I love big cities because you can be independent.
- b. In short, big cities attract me because there are so many things to do.
- c. In brief, I like big cities because of their energy and freedom.

**PARAGRAPH 2**

There are two reasons I hate big cities. First of all, big cities are noisy 24 hours a day. You can hear horns honking, traffic roaring, music blaring, and people talking at all hours. It is never quiet in a big city. Second, there is no feeling of community in big cities. No one knows or cares about you. Neighbors who have lived next door to each other for many years don't even know each others' names. That can make life extremely lonely. \_\_\_\_\_

- a. In brief, big cities are noisy, lonely places to live.
- b. In conclusion, I prefer to live in a small town, where it is quieter and people are friendlier.
- c. Also, big cities have a lot of crime.



- A** Read the paragraphs. Write a concluding sentence for each one.

**PARAGRAPH 1**

Successful young fashion designers usually have three characteristics. First of all, they must be very creative. They must use their artistic abilities and their knowledge of textiles and colors. Second, they must be willing to work hard over a long period of time. Usually, young fashion designers start out as poorly paid assistants or as unpaid interns. They must work many long hours for little or no pay to learn the needed skills. Finally, successful young fashion designers must be well-organized and understand the importance of building an outstanding portfolio. A portfolio is a large folder with sketches, photos, and samples of a designer's work. It is visual proof of a designer's talent, vision, and accomplishments. \_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_

**PARAGRAPH 2**

I find that being a computer salesperson is a very rewarding job. First, my job allows me to meet many different types of people. I like this because I'm an outgoing person, and I enjoy talking with people and finding out about them. Second, my job requires me to problem-solve and find creative ways to meet my customers' needs. I find it satisfying to figure out which of my company's products are best for my clients. Third, the job requires me to learn about new developments in my field. I find this part of the job satisfying because I like staying informed, and I love the challenge of learning new things. \_\_\_\_\_

\_\_\_\_\_